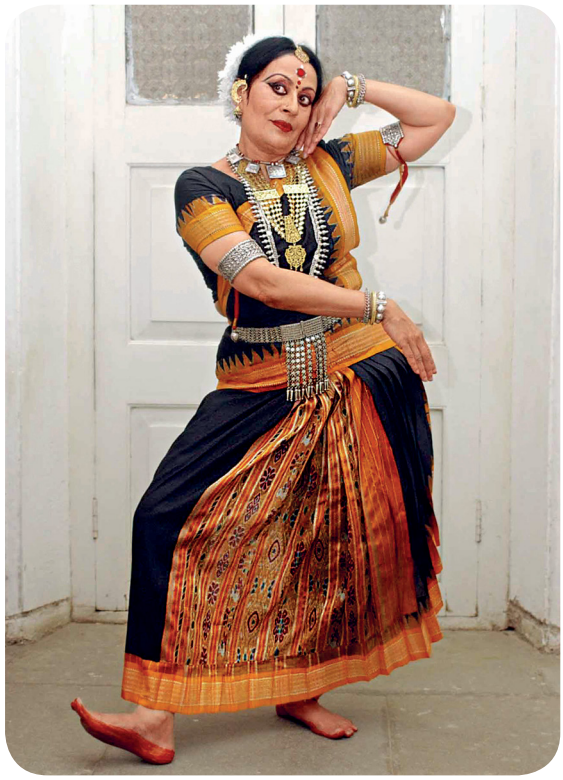


BCCL

Sonal Mansingh

(1944–)

Smart, educated, city-bred and born to power, Sonal Pakvasa nee Mansingh, has carved a special place for herself in the Indian dance pantheon, and became the first dancer to be nominated to Parliament. She is well-versed in two dance forms, Bharatanatyam and Odissi. She is well-read, too, with lateral knowledge and worldwide exposure—a sharp mind with an equally sharp memory. She blends spunk with substance, ability with authority. She is a woman who knows how to rule a man's world. Babus are afraid of her temper, and netas dance to her tunes. If Indian dance can be thought of as a journey that started way back in 1947, she is its current pole star.

Padma Subrahmanyam

(1943–)

Born to a family of filmmakers, musicians and artists, Padma was a natural. She, however, had an academic mind and did seminal research in dance and South Indian temple sculptures and learnt about *karanas*, which she made her lifetime work. She created her own style, Padma Natyam, based on the *karanas*–practically making Bharatanatyam leap out from temple walls to the stage. The films made by her illustrious father, director K. Subramanyam, also helped give a mass appeal to the dance form. Thus marrying theory with practice, Padma extends the aesthetic universe envisaged in the *Natyashastra* of Bharatamuni, whose cause she espouses. One of the foremost dance academics in India, she has crafted a memorial for Bharatamuni and Ilango at Pattipulam village near Chennai, where she has recreated a gallery of the 108 *karanas*. Her own niece, Mahati, is a delight to watch too.



INDIA PICTURE